

Look for anything that makes you feel uncomfortable or is just objectively unsightly or seedy. There's no excuse for buying a house, living there for a week, then being caught by surprise by the "gentleman's club" you didn't realize was three blocks down the road.

Ask yourself how these neighborhood features will impact your own standard of living, then consider how they will impact the life of a hypothetical, picky future home buyer to whom you're trying to sell the home. Imagine them walking around your house, gushing about the hardwood floors and spacious yard, then stepping outside to a breath of fresh air that smells peculiarly like the dog food factory across the street.

Though you may be able to fix up the ugly features of a home itself, you need to keep in mind all those neighborhood features you can't possibly alter. Petition all you want, but you won't be able to shut down that dog food factory, and the delicious aroma of dog food can significantly slow your home's appreciation rate over time.

Once you're done scouting the location as it is now, ask yourself what the neighborhood will look like at different times of the year. For example, in a snowy part of the country, a home with a driveway facing south will see snow melt faster than a home facing north. Is the direction the house faces a deal breaker? No. Is it something to file away when deciding between two otherwise similar properties? Absolutely.

Also be aware of activities that vary by season. A home next to a football stadium will bring fun lifestyle opportunities on game days, but it will also bring traffic jams, congestion, and maybe a bit of litter. A home next to a school offers a great opportunity for families to send their kiddos over without a commute, but it also brings daily bus and foot traffic during the school year. You might not be able to see these things if you purchase your home on a sleepy summer day, so try to ask local residents how the atmosphere varies in the area throughout the year.

Also note that seasonal patterns can be a good thing—some people will pay more, not less, to own a house that's close to exciting events in their community. The main point is to limit surprises down the road. Go into the purchase with your eyes (and ears and nostrils) wide open.

Be the Worst That You Can Be